The Conception of "Post-Classicism" in Art

Sheng, Tong*

Abstract

The proposal of a conception of *post-classicism* in art arises from an implicit yet compelling necessity within the global cultural configuration of the post-globalization era. Examined through a theoretical framework centered on the relationship between civilization and culture, and evaluated according to the dual criteria of ontological poetics and aesthetics, this conception reveals a clearly articulated international philosophical mission. By analyzing artistic paradigms across the Western historical periods commonly designated as classical, modern, postmodern, and contemporary, this article identifies an ontological deficiency underlying the formation of persistent artistic problems. On this basis, it seeks to clarify a possible philosophical orientation for the future international development of art.

Keywords: post-classicism; international art; post-globalization; Lao–Zhuang philosophy; humanism

1. Cultural Background and Theoretical Framework

The conception of post-classicism in art is grounded in two objective cultural conditions: first, the advent of the post-globalization era; and second, the exposure of so-called "universal values" as contingent expressions of unilateral interest. The former has been described by Western scholars as the transformation of globalization from a "flat" world into a "curved" one,[1] while the latter has been revealed through explicit political declarations that foreground national interest above all else. Against this background, contemporary international artistic thought—when examined through a framework centered on the relationship between civilization and culture—may be understood as implicitly gesturing toward a post-classicist orientation.

---

* Sheng Tong is an independent scholar based in Sydney, Australia. He holds a PhD from the University of Technology Sydney, Australia.

[1] Thomas L. Friedman, *The World Is Flat: A Brief History of the Twenty-First Century* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2005); David M. Smick, *The World Is Curved: Hidden Dangers to the Global Economy* (New York: Portfolio, 2008); Harold L. Sirkin et al., *Globality: Competing with Everyone from Everywhere for Everything* (New York: Business Plus, 2012).

The concepts of *civilization* and *culture* have long been conflated.[2] In this article, civilization refers to the degree to which human cognitive consciousness is constructed in a correct direction—namely, toward the good—whereas culture denotes the general outcome of the practical application of that consciousness in lived reality. Civilization admits only of higher or lower degrees, while culture may be judged as good or bad. The criterion of correctness in civilization may be articulated through Lao–Zhuang philosophy, in which *shan* (善) functions as the poetic principle of goodness and *de* (德) as the aesthetic principle of virtue.[3]

2. Defining the Concept of Post-Classicism

In Chinese discourse, the term "classic" does not constitute a rigorously delimited concept. Unlike "classical," which refers to temporal duration or historical continuity, "classic" designates a qualitative property. Within the civilization–culture framework, the classic should be understood as a category of cultural achievement rather than a civilizational one, and only insofar as it contributes to the elevation of civilization. To designate cultural products that hinder civilizational progress as classics entails a logical contradiction.

From the perspective of Lao–Zhuang philosophy, *shan* represents the affirmative, constant, and unchanging content of the Dao and forms the core of Lao–Zhuang poetics, while *de* represents the positive, dynamic, and efficacious manifestation of the Dao and constitutes the core of Lao–Zhuang aesthetics. Accordingly, a classic may be defined as a cultural achievement that preserves *shan* while manifesting *de*. This criterion allows for the exclusion of deleterious cultural elements and the retention of those capable of expressing the heights to which human civilization has ascended.

Having entered the third decade of the twenty-first century, globalization has largely become nominal, while the rhetoric of universal values has revealed itself as a discourse of unilateral dominance. The succession of geopolitical conflicts in the post-pandemic era signals the arrival of a post-globalization epoch grounded in the genuine sharing of human civilizational achievements. At this historical juncture, the redefinition of the classic at the cultural level may provide the international community with a principled standpoint for comprehensive development. To distinguish this concept from earlier, semantically ambiguous usages, I adopt the term *post-classicism*, thereby establishing its conceptual logic.

---

[2] Harry Elmer Barnes and Henry David, *The History of Western Civilization*, vol. 2 (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Company, 1935); Niall Ferguson, *Civilization: The West and the Rest* (New York: Penguin Press, 2011), xxv–xxvi.

[3] *Zhuangzi*, trans. Burton Watson (New York: Columbia University Press, 1968), 20, 62.

3. The International Philosophical Mission of Post-Classicism

Post-classicism is fundamentally philosophical in nature. Positioned at the level of human civilization, it is capable of exerting a guiding influence on emerging cultural phenomena. Under the international political vision of a "community with a shared future for humankind," its forward-looking philosophical significance becomes particularly evident.

At the level of appearance, art in the early twenty-first century mirrors a broader condition of global disorder. Both artistic theory and practice exhibit fragmentation characterized by self-referential isolation. The only apparent principle is the pursuit of difference for its own sake: the strange is treated as remarkable, the remarkable as novel, and the novel as superior. Artistic production thus risks devolving into a form of cultural pathology devoid of civilizational value.

The historical roots of this condition may be traced through the trajectory of Western art. If the problem of classical art concerned the correctness of standards, the problem of modern art lay in the transformation of subject–object relations in the establishment of standards. In postmodern and contemporary art, the problem devolved into the question of whether standards should exist at all.

Western classical art generally designates the dominant artistic forms of the Italian Renaissance as well as those of ancient Greece and Rome.[4] Classicism as an artistic doctrine has been variously defined,[5] often associated with Cartesian rationalism and seventeenth-century Paris. The foundational aesthetic principle underlying ancient Greek and Roman art derives from the Pythagorean doctrine of order and proportion, later affirmed by Plato and Aristotle.[6]

Western modern consciousness emerged in the 1860s and 1870s, most notably in Baudelaire's articulation of the avant-garde.[7] In the narrower sense, modern art is often traced to French Impressionism, while modernism designates the broader artistic ideology spanning

---

[4] Fred S. Kleiner and Christin J. Mamiya, *Gardner s Art through the Ages: A Global History* (Boston: Cengage Learning, 2016), 177.

[5] Dominique Secrétan, *Classicism* (Beijing: Kunlun Press, 1989).

[6] Władysław Tatarkiewicz, *A History of Six Ideas: An Essay in Aesthetics* (Warsaw: Polish Scientific Publishers, 1980), 167–68.

[7] Richard R. Brettell, *Modern Art, 1851–1929* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), 12–13.

approximately 1885 to 1925.[8] Modernism emphasized human subjectivity and humanist principles, rejecting the objective formal aesthetics of classicism and thereby introducing a latent philosophical problem concerning the definition of the human subject.

Postmodern art emerged in the United States in the latter half of the twentieth century. Postmodernism arose as a reaction against modernism's elitism and rule-based authority, yet its radical inclusivity renders it resistant to precise definition.[9] Leslie Fiedler's decision to publish in *Playboy* symbolized this anti-modernist stance.[10]

Contemporary art is notoriously difficult to define. Institutions adopted the term as early as 1910, while Arthur C. Danto locates its emergence in the 1970s.[11] Some theorists describe contemporary art as "post-conceptual."[12] Danto characterizes it as lacking style, narrative direction, or aesthetic absolutes, describing it as "post-historical."[13] In doing so, contemporary art becomes itself a philosophical condition.

When examined within the civilization–culture framework, this situation reveals a deeper problem: Western art, as a cultural phenomenon, rests upon a flawed civilizational foundation rooted in philosophy. Western philosophy failed to sustain Heraclitus's concept of *logos* as a

---

[8] Frederick R. Karl, *Modern and Modernism: The Sovereignty of the Artist, 1885–1925* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1985), 12–13, 21.

[9] Jean-François Lyotard, *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984).

[10] Leslie Fiedler, "Cross the Border—Close the Gap," *Playboy* 16, no. 12 (1969).

[11] Arthur C. Danto, *After the End of Art: Contemporary Art and the Pale of History* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1997), 6.

[12] Peter Osborne, "Contemporary Art Is Post-Conceptual Art," lecture, Kingston University, July 2010.

[13] Danto, *After the End of Art*, 14–16.

shared ontological principle.[14] Consequently, Western poetics and aesthetics never formed stable ontological criteria, remaining largely subjective or formal.[15]

This ontological deficiency is inseparable from the unresolved definition of the human. Lao–Zhuang philosophy conceives the human as unified with Heaven and inherently endowed with *shan* and *de*. Western philosophy, beginning with Protagoras, elevated the human as the measure of all things,[16] culminating in the crisis Nietzsche described as the "death of God."[17] Creativity was desacralized and extended from divine creation to human fabrication.[18] Classical ideals thus became hollow, modernism inevitable, postmodernism a cosmetic rehabilitation of disorder, and contemporary art an attempt to rebrand this disorder as humanity itself.

Against this historical-philosophical backdrop, post-classicism seeks to reintroduce ontological criteria grounded in Lao–Zhuang poetics and aesthetics, thereby reconstructing the philosophical foundation of international art. Contemporary Chinese art, which emerged after 1976 and absorbed Western modern and contemporary paradigms, illustrates the urgency of this task.[19]

Conclusion

Post-classicism affirms an artistic position aligned with the ideal of a community with a shared future for humankind. It rejects the reduction of art to political instrumentality or capitalist subordination and instead seeks to articulate artistic expressions grounded in *shan* and *de*. By dismantling civilizational barriers and constructing a pluralistic framework, post-classicism enables diverse cultures to communicate their civilizational achievements and to contribute to the formation of a genuinely universal global society.

---

[14] D. J. O'Connor, ed., *A Critical History of Western Philosophy* (New York: Free Press, 1964), 6–7.

[15] Jean Bessière et al., eds., *A History of Poetics* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1990).

[16] O'Connor, *Critical History of Western Philosophy*, 22–23.

[17] Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, trans. Walter Kaufmann (New York: Penguin Classics, 1978), 4.

[18] Tatarkiewicz, *A History of Six Ideas*, 340–41.

[19] Ma Xiaoxiang and Chen Yunhai, eds., *Trends in Contemporary Art Thought* (Nanjing: Nanjing University Press, 2016), 193–214.

Bibliography

Barnes, Harry Elmer, and Henry David. *The History of Western Civilization*. Vol. 2. New York: Harcourt, Brace and Company, 1935.

Bessière, Jean, et al., eds. *A History of Poetics*. Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1990.

Brettell, Richard R. *Modern Art, 1851–1929*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999.

Danto, Arthur C. *After the End of Art: Contemporary Art and the Pale of History*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1997.

Ferguson, Niall. *Civilization: The West and the Rest*. New York: Penguin Press, 2011.

Fiedler, Leslie. "Cross the Border—Close the Gap." *Playboy* 16, no. 12 (1969).

Friedman, Thomas L. *The World Is Flat: A Brief History of the Twenty-First Century*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2005.

Karl, Frederick R. *Modern and Modernism: The Sovereignty of the Artist, 1885–1925*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1985.

Kleiner, Fred S., and Christin J. Mamiya. *Gardner s Art through the Ages: A Global History*. 14th ed. Boston: Cengage Learning, 2016.

Lyotard, Jean-François. *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*. Translated by Walter Kaufmann. New York: Penguin Classics, 1978.

O'Connor, D. J., ed. *A Critical History of Western Philosophy*. New York: Free Press, 1964.

Osborne, Peter. "Contemporary Art Is Post-Conceptual Art." Lecture, Kingston University, July 2010.

Secrétan, Dominique. *Classicism*. Beijing: Kunlun Press, 1989.

Sirkin, Harold L., George S. Day, and Jamal Shamsie. *Globality: Competing with Everyone from Everywhere for Everything*. New York: Business Plus, 2012.

Smick, David M. *The World Is Curved: Hidden Dangers to the Global Economy*. New York: Portfolio, 2008.

Tatarkiewicz, Władysław. *A History of Six Ideas: An Essay in Aesthetics*. Warsaw: Polish Scientific Publishers, 1980.

Zhuangzi. *Zhuangzi*. Translated by Burton Watson. New York: Columbia University Press, 1968.